A FREEBIE THAT FREES WOMEN

Pioneering studies on Odisha's Subhadra Yojana reveal an encouraging picture: cash in hand is also expanding female autonomy and enterprise

By **Arkamoy Datta Majumdar** *in Bhubaneswar*

It **is a near-ubiquitous feature of state budgets now: direct cash transfers to women. In state after state,** it has won power for parties across the spectrum, swelling the ranks of women voters, even weaning them away from the default political choices of their class. Arguments for and against it are conducted largely at the fiscal level. "Can states afford it?" Or, "is this welfare or just a freebie?" Nobody bothered to ask the women, to map what the crores of budgetary outgo is doing at the level of individuals and families. Till now.

Odisha is filling that blank with pioneering micro-studies of its Subhadra Yojana. The results contain enough data points to make sceptical policymakers think again. Caveats do exist, but not of a sort that negate the premise—instead, they serve as signposts that every state could benefit from.

Launched in September 2024, Subhadra Yojana provides eligible women aged between 21 and 60 with Rs 10,000 every year for five years—to help create livelihoods and financial autonomy. It covers a majority of eligible women across Odisha: a staggering 10.2 million, to whom over Rs 20,648 crore has gone out since the launch.

So, what's the experiential record? Two impact assessments—one by the

CASE STUDY

"I can give my children a better quality of life"

Bangali Barada *(second from left), 42, with fellow Jai Siya Ram SHG members, near Bhubaneswar*

Abandoned by her husband, Barada worked for years as a domestic cook to support her two children: a daughter studying pharmacy and a son pursuing cricket dreams in Ranchi. There was little room for her own dreams. The Subhadra scheme changed that. With its financial support, she began making and selling food products through her self-help group. "I was earning before too. But with Subhadra, I can give my children a better quality of life," she says.

